

Simon play still leaves them laughing

By BETTY LIGON

Neil Simon never grows stale. The one-liners he wrote in the 1950's come across just as funny today with just the teeniest updating.

His play "Barefoot in the Park," playing at Tegemeyer's in Las Cruces under the CMC Productions banner, occasions spasms of laughter just as it has for the last 20 years.

DIRECTOR Craig McConnell helps it along a little by taking a few liberties with the lines, but he was more than aided and abetted by a bang-up good cast. For anyone who may have forgotten, "Barefoot" concerns a newlywed couple of six days in their first apartment — a walk-up on the fifth floor.

To this empty efficiency in the first act come a telephone installation man, a United Parcel deliveryman, the bride's mother and the young husband, all in varying states of climbing exhaustion, there to be greeted by the delightfully doty bride. Also passing through this menage is the man upstairs, who must enter his digs through their bedroom window.

Edith Bowser, the doyen of El Paso theater, is the catalyst that keep this comedy bounding. She squeezes every possible laugh out of the role of the flappy mother with a gesture, a moue at the right moment, stopping just short of broad slapstick.

A COUPLE of newcomers to CMC Productions give a professional rendition of the newlyweds. Hank Cohen makes a proper, pragmatic, yet embryonic, lawyer while Linell Wenzel is his quixotic and pretty wife. This is the third play for Cohen, who is just finishing a degree in Radio and Television at UT El Paso. Ms. Wenzel has been active in Army theater in Germany and directed the last play at the Ft. Bliss Moulin Rouge Dinner Theater.

Veteran actors taking small roles and turning them into polished gems are Larry Bettis as the eccentric man upstairs, Louie Torres, who successfully hid his leading man stature under a floppy cap and curious accent as the telephone man and McConnell, who spoke not a word. He played the winded deliveryman to the hilt, crawling through the door like a harpooned walrus, gasping and walleyed.

McConnell is not only a good actor and director. He is a great set designer. Single-handedly he built this set, bare bones for the first act, then quickly dressed the other two acts to make a reasonable, attractive apartment, complete with kitchenette.

IN ONE performance the wall hangings were tacked up so hurriedly between acts, that the cuphanger came tumbling down in the middle of a fight between the young lovers. Never turning a hair, they carried on beautifully while disposing of the mess.

Pacing may have been a bit off, but the audience was oblivious. The only real distraction was the door to the bedroom. It was constantly being used, but each time it was carefully closed as if to hide a roomful of skeletons. We realize it purposely hid the empty backstage, but an illusion of bedroom would help.

Dick-Tegemeyer has a good thing going with the dinner theater concept. The meals are tasty, not expensive and the playgoer has a choice of eating or not. The show will come to a couple of El Paso country clubs this month. Otherwise catch it Fridays and Saturdays in Las Cruces this month.